

4. The developed capacity to render judgments with integrity under conditions of ethical uncertainty.
5. An organized approach to learning from experience, both individually and collectively, and thus of growing new knowledge from the context of practice.
6. The development of a professional community responsible for the oversight and monitoring of quality in both practice and professional educators.

Daedalus then added these wonderful words: “*The primary feature of any profession [is] to serve responsibly, selflessly, and wisely . . . and to establish [an] inherently ethical relationship between the professional and the general society.*”

Times Have Changed

When we think of professionals, most of us would probably start with physicians, lawyers, teachers, engineers, architects, accountants, and clergymen. I think we could also find agreement that both journalists and trustees of other people’s money are—at least in the ideal—professionals as well. And yet, profession by profession, the old values are clearly being undermined. The driving force in this instance, as in so many others, is our bottom-line society, focused on our ability to count with precision what doesn’t count at all. Unchecked market forces not only constitute a strong challenge to society’s traditional trust in our professions, but in some cases these forces have totally overwhelmed normative standards of professional conduct, developed over centuries.

Sad to say, the financial services industry—including the mutual fund industry to which I’ve devoted my entire career—seems to be leading the way in the development of these baneful forces, as in many other deteriorating values that do not bring credit on us. Once a profession in which business was subservient, the field of money management has become a business in which the idea of professional conduct is subservient.